

AI Ethics

Course Num: SEIS 651-01 & 2

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Week 4

The background image shows a misty mountain landscape. In the foreground and middle ground, there are dense evergreen forests covering steep slopes. Mist or low clouds are visible between the forested ridges and in the valleys. The sky is a pale, hazy blue. A semi-transparent dark blue horizontal banner is positioned across the middle of the image, serving as a background for the title text.

From Foundations to Fundamentals of Ethics

Agenda

Focus Area: Fundamentals of Ethics

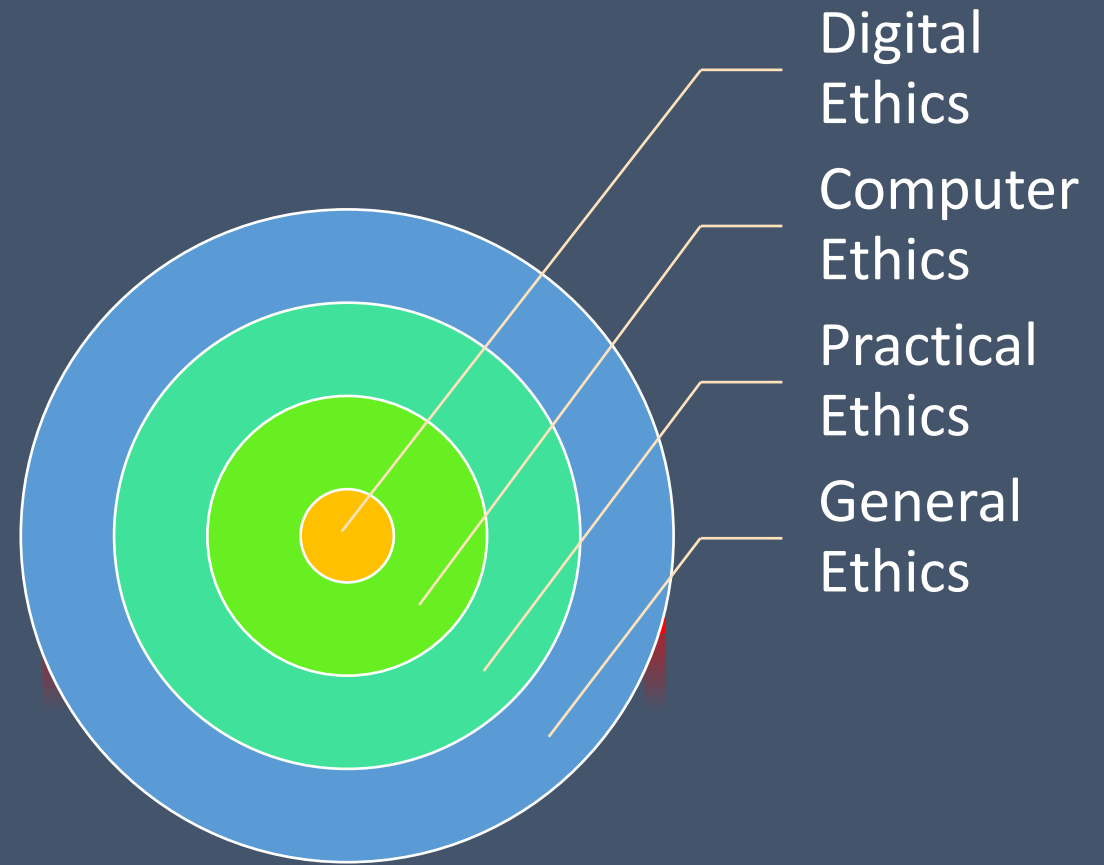
Essential Questions:

- How does variability affect ethical constructs?
- What is needed to control for these variables?

What is the focal point?

What are these questions getting at?

- 1) Is it good or bad?
- 2) Is it right or wrong?
- 3) Is it evil?
- 4) Is it expected?



Examining Harm

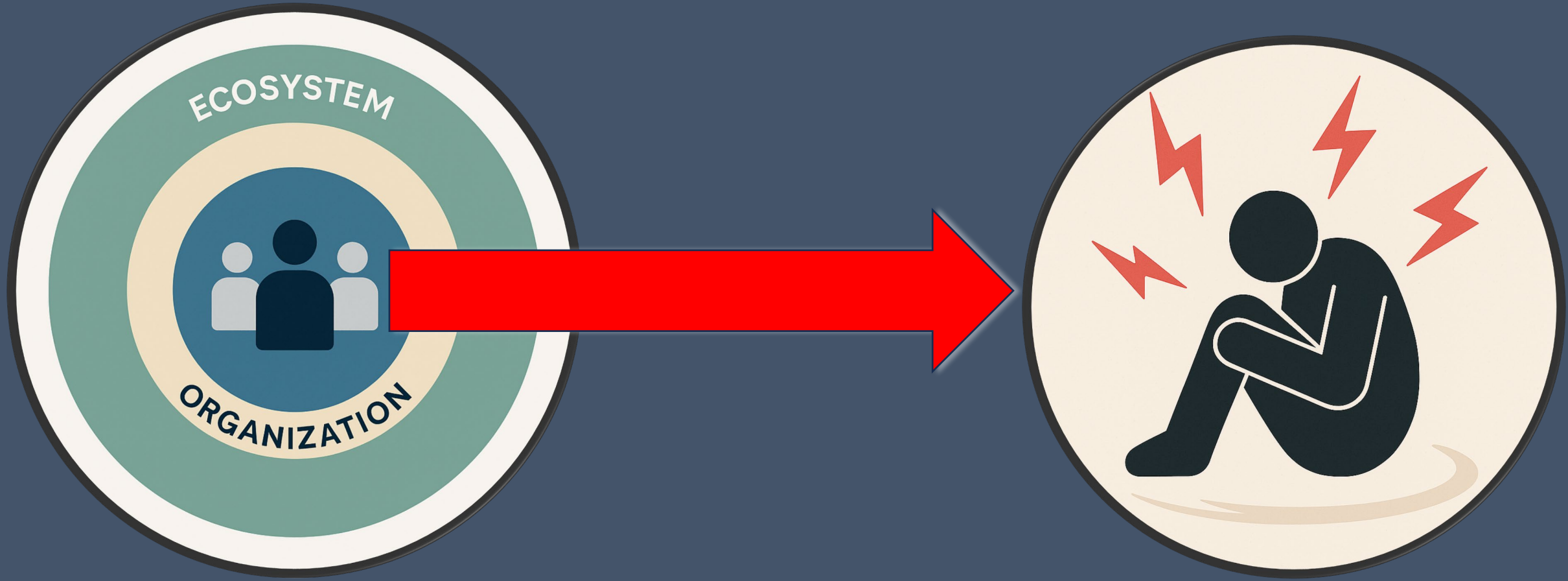
NIST AI 100-1

AI RMF 1.0



Fig. 1. Examples of potential harms related to AI systems. Trustworthy AI systems and their responsible use can mitigate negative risks and contribute to benefits for people, organizations, and ecosystems.

Examining Harm



Images AI Generated with Co-Pilot. 2/23/2026

Where harm Potentially grows exponentially

As outlined in the NIST AI RMF:

“Inscrutability: Inscrutable AI systems can complicate risk measurement. Inscrutability can be a result of the opaque nature of AI systems (limited explainability or interpretability), lack of transparency or documentation in AI system development or deployment, or inherent uncertainties in AI systems.” –page 6

Where harm Potentially grows exponentially

As outlined in the NIST AI RMF:

“Human baseline: Risk management of AI systems that are intended to augment or replace human activity, for example decision making, requires some form of baseline metrics for comparison. This is difficult to systematize since AI systems carry out different tasks – and perform tasks differently – than humans.” page 6

What is an AI system?

“an engineered or machine-based system that can, for a given set of objectives, generate outputs such as predictions, recommendations, or decision influencing real or virtual environments...designed to operate with varying levels of autonomy.”

-NIST AI RMF:2023, as adapted from OCED
Recommendation on AI:2019

What Can an AI System unintentionally Do?

- “designed to operate with varying levels of autonomy.”
- Autonomy can cause chaos especially when left unstructured.
- AI Autonomy could present a Fackler situation.

What Can an AI System unintentionally Do?



POLICE ACADEMY 6

Ethics and responsibility



Ethics and responsibility

- Seinfeld's thoughts



- What are the reasons why people do not want accountability?

AI risks should be examined by a multi-disciplinary team based on context, not done in isolation or independently

Te



From Appendix C, NIST AI RMF, Fundamentals

Human roles and responsibilities in decision making and overseeing AI systems need to be clearly defined and differentiated.

From Appendix C, NIST AI RMF, Fundamentals

Decisions that go into the design, development, evaluation and use of AI systems reflect systemic and human cognitive biases.

From Appendix C, NIST AI RMF, Fundamentals

Human-AI interaction results vary.

From Appendix C, NIST AI RMF, Fundamentals

Presenting AI system information to humans is complex.

Activity 1

Tech Accountability

What is this case about?

How does AI factor into the case?

What are the AI ethics issues that are exposed?

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Tech Accountability



Tech Accountability

What is the “win” in this settlement? What was achieved?

Do you consider this settlement to be ethical?

Find the Similarities



Find the Similarities



How are the META, Ford, and Phillip Morris Cases Similar?

- Come up with your own list
- Here is mine:
 - All represent firsts. Ford was the only criminal trial.
 - These take time, the Phillip Morris trial went from 1999-2006.
 - Each trial has and will lead to a refined approach as the health and safety of people is explored.
 - Each represents a larger group of people: Pinto owners and all drivers, Phillip Morris smokers and all smokers, and Meta is all META users and social media users as well.

Reflection

- What are the factors that cause an AI System to create HARM?
- What is HARM an effective focus when determine AI ethical impact?